

Sleeping Bear Dunes National Lakeshore - Visitor Guide

Destination: Sleeping Bear Dunes National Lakeshore, Michigan

Overview

Sleeping Bear Dunes National Lakeshore is a 71,187-acre park along the shoreline of Lake Michigan, near Empire, Michigan, including North and South Manitou Islands. Established in 1970, it draws nearly two million visitors a year to its dunes, beaches, bluffs, forests, and historic landscapes. The dunes are part of the largest freshwater dune system in the world, with the tallest known as perched dunes, formed from sand piled atop glacial moraines left by retreating glaciers roughly 14,000 years ago.

Local Legend

The Anishinaabe legend of Sleeping Bear tells of a mother bear and her two cubs who swam across Lake Michigan fleeing famine. Exhausted, the cubs drowned within sight of shore; the bear climbed the bluff to watch for them, and the two cubs resurfaced as the Manitou Islands. The bear is said to still lie there, watching over her children, giving Sleeping Bear Dune its name.

Things to See and Do

Pierce Stocking Scenic Drive: A 7.4-mile scenic drive with stops offering spectacular views of dunes, beaches, and inland lakes. Dune Climb: A popular spot where visitors run up a tall dune; a signature Sleeping Bear Dunes experience. Manitou Islands: Reachable via seasonal ferry from Leland, Michigan (May-September); largely wilderness, ideal for backpacking trips that require a permit and offer real solitude. Port Oneida Rural Historic District: The nation's largest publicly owned historic agricultural landscape, settled predominantly by German and Prussian immigrants in the 1800s. Glen Haven Historic Village: A former stop for lake steamships, now home to a boat museum, general store, and blacksmith shop. Sleeping Bear Point US Life-Saving Service Station Maritime Museum: Located just west of Glen Haven, telling the story of the surfmen who rescued over 178,000 people from shipwrecks between 1871 and 1915. South Manitou Lighthouse: Built in 1839 to help ships navigate the Manitou Passage, a 36-mile shipping lane known for dangerous shoals and sandbars.

Hidden Gems

North Bar Lake and Empire Bluff, visible from Pierce Stocking Scenic Drive, offer a quieter combination of inland lake, forested dunes, and bluff views away from the busiest beach areas. The Sleeping Bear

Heritage Trail offers a groomed, multi-use path for hiking and biking away from the main roads, and portions are groomed for winter cross-country skiing. Loon Lake, off M-22, offers quieter inland lake access with a floating dock and transfer system, less crowded than the main Lake Michigan beaches.

Local Tips and Safety

Watch out for poison ivy - avoid its three leaflets, stems, berries, and roots, all of which can cause a severe reaction. Check often for ticks and remove them promptly. Conditions on Lake Michigan can change rapidly; boaters should monitor weather reports and carry safety gear, navigation charts, and extra fuel. Swimmers should be aware of rip current conditions. Stay off steep and snow-covered dunes; climbing is recommended only at the designated Dune Climb.

Regulations

Drive only on established roads. Keep pets on a leash; they are permitted on hiking trails April 1 through November 30 but are not allowed at North Bar Lake, on the Manitou Islands, in backcountry campgrounds, on the Dune Climb, or on some swimming beaches. Fires are permitted only in fire rings and picnic fireplaces; beach fires are restricted to bare sand between the water and the first dune. Glass containers are prohibited in areas used for sunbathing, swimming, or wading. Drones are prohibited without a permit.

FAQ: What kind of camping is available?

The park offers modern sites and facilities at Platte River Campground, a more rustic experience at D.H. Day Campground, and backcountry camping at a walk-in campground on the mainland or on the Manitou Islands. Campers may only collect dead and down wood, and none from the dunes.

FAQ: What is there to do in winter?

From mid-November to late March, the dunes become a winter destination for cross-country skiing and snowshoeing, including ranger-led snowshoe hikes. About 50 miles of marked trails are ungroomed, while portions of the Sleeping Bear Heritage Trail are groomed. Snowmobiling is prohibited except on rights-of-way along some state and county roads.

FAQ: Is stargazing good here?

Yes. The park highlights its truly dark skies as critical to nocturnal wildlife habitats, and visitors are encouraged to ask a ranger how to help protect the night sky while stargazing.

FAQ: How do I reach the Manitou Islands?

Ferry service to the Manitou Islands operates from Leland, Michigan, from May to September, via Manitou Island Transit. A camping permit is required for overnight stays, and no commercial services are available on the islands.